

JAMALPUR LOCOMOTIVE WORKSHOP

The first locomotive, carriage, and wagon workshop facility for the East Indian Railway (EIR) was set up in Howrah, Calcutta, in 1854. This was done in a hurry to manufacture replacement coaches when the ships carrying imported coaches to India sank. However, as the railways grew, the workshop ran into problems related to skilled labour and space, necessitating a move to another site.

On 8 February 1862, the EIR established a larger workshop in Jamalpur, 10 km south of Monghyr (now Munger), in Bihar. The site was strategically selected, as in those days, Monghyr had traditional communities of mechanics and manufacturers of ironware and firearms, and other skilled artisans, so much so that the town was called “Birmingham of the East”. Initially, the workshop was meant for minor repairs and periodic overhauling. It gradually progressed towards self-sufficiency with various manufacturing facilities, including a steam-operated rolling mill (1870), Iron (1893) and Steel (1898) Foundry, a signal equipment shop (1894), the Jamalpur Technical Institute with a chemical and metallurgical laboratory (1897), and a steam power plant (1901).

By the turn of the century, the workshop had started manufacturing locomotives, beginning with CA 764 “*Lady Curzon*” in 1899. It was the first facility to produce indigenously conceptualized rail cranes, tower cars (Mark II and Mark III), and breakdown cranes. It also pioneered the manufacturing of high-capacity electrical lifting jacks, electrical arc furnaces, wheel sets, fireboxes, permanent-way fixtures, steel castings, bolts and nuts, and various machines for ticketing. The workshop was heavily damaged in an earthquake in 1934 and was remodelled from 1935 to 1937. The layout was changed to increase the workload capacity and during World War II, it also produced shells, mortars, and bombs.